



## VEHICLE ACQUISITION RESEARCH

# Jeep Wrangler, Nationwide

Reliable years only - filtered automatically from the VIN

|                |                                                                                                              |
|----------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| DRIVER         | High-school student, daily school runs and Colorado ski trips                                                |
| BUDGET         | \$7,000 - \$12,000 (carried over from the teen-car brief)                                                    |
| SEARCH         | Nationwide, United States. Dry states preferred.                                                             |
| APPROVED YEARS | JK (preferred): 2015-2017, plus 2014 as second tier.<br>TJ with the 4.0 inline six: 2003-2004.               |
| FILTER RESULT  | 8 shortlisted - 1 conditional - 7 for review - 12 excluded<br>(28 vehicles, every VIN authenticated offline) |
| REPORT DATE    | October 04, 2026                                                                                             |

### The short answer

Reliable-year Wranglers are reachable for \$12,000 nationwide - but only as **two-door 2014-2016 JK Sports with roughly 100,000-150,000 miles**, or a **2003-2004 TJ**. Four-door Unlimiteds in the good years start above your ceiling. The strongest leads are dry-state 2015-2016 two-doors in California and Arizona. Read Section 2 before buying: the TJ has no stability control, and any good-year JK priced far below book is almost certainly hiding a branded title.

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## 1. What the search found

Every listing was put through an automatic filter (Section 3) that reads the model year, generation and engine from the VIN rather than the advert, then applies your rules: bad years out, JK preferred, inline-six TJs allowed only in their best years. It also removes total-loss and out-of-country cars, and anything over budget. Of 28 vehicles, 8 made the shortlist.

### The four leads worth calling first

**1. 1C4AJWAGXFL566836 - 2015 JK Sport, \$11,499.** Filter rank 1: a best-rated year, in budget and priced in line with book. Location and mileage were not indexed - ask both first.

**2. 1C4AJWAG7FL574988 - 2015 JK Sport automatic, Mesa AZ.** Rank 2. Advertised as a 2014; the VIN proves 2015, which moves it up a tier. Dry climate and an automatic - easier for a new driver. Get price and mileage.

**3. 1C4AJWAG9GL189210 - 2016 JK Sport, 91,322 mi, Upland CA.** Rank 3, and the car I would most like to own: best-rated year, the lowest mileage of any two-door found, dry Southern California. It ranks third only because no price was indexed - a 2016 Sport books at \$13,270-\$15,620, so it may land over budget.

**4. 1J4FA49S34P771921 - 2004 TJ Sport 4.0, 5-speed, \$10,859, 135,658 mi, Garner NC.** Rank 7, but the best inline-six: the only one with complete data, a best TJ year and a fair price. A manual with no stability control (Section 2), and North Carolina treats winter roads, so inspect the frame.

Rank 4, a 2016 Sport S at \$11,999 in Chantilly VA, is left off this list on purpose: it is a Virginia road-salt car with 141,399 miles. It stays on the shortlist in Section 6 if the dry-state options fall through.

## 2. The caveats

You asked for more of these. In order of how much they should affect the decision:

| Caveat                                         | Why it matters                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |             |
|------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------|
| <b>The TJ has no stability control</b>         | Electronic stability control became standard on the Wrangler with the 2007 JK. No TJ has it. It is one of the IIHS baseline requirements for a teen car and the single strongest reason to prefer the JK for this driver. Neither generation has side-curtain airbags. | <b>HIGH</b> |
| <b>Budget forces high miles and two doors</b>  | The approved years book at \$10,930-\$15,810 for two-doors and from \$12,200 for Unlimiteds. At \$12,000 expect a two-door Sport with 100k-150k miles. About \$13,000-\$14,000 buys noticeably lower miles; that is the stretch worth considering if any is.           | <b>MED</b>  |
| <b>Cheap good-year JKs are usually branded</b> | A 2015-2016 well under book is the price signature of a salvage or rebuilt title, or a major fault. The filter flags anything more than 15% under book. Treat it as branded until an NMVTIS check says otherwise.                                                      | <b>HIGH</b> |
| <b>Part-time 4WD on both generations</b>       | Both are rear-wheel drive until the driver engages 4WD, and 4WD must not be left on over dry pavement. Teach when to use 4H, and fit winter tyres - Colorado's November 2025 traction-law update requires rated tyres even on 4WD vehicles.                            | <b>MED</b>  |
| <b>Many of these are manuals</b>               | Most TJs found are 5-speed manuals, and several 2014 JKs are 6-speed manuals. A stick is one more thing for a new driver to manage. The VIN does not encode the transmission - confirm it from the listing.                                                            | <b>MED</b>  |
| <b>A 2003-2004 TJ is 22-23 years old</b>       | The 4.0 is famously durable, but rubber, bushings, wiring and seals have aged regardless of mileage. Parts are cheap; labour still adds up.                                                                                                                            | <b>NOTE</b> |

| Caveat                          | Why it matters                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |      |
|---------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------|
| Still not on the IIHS teen list | Nothing about this filter changes the earlier safety finding. Within the Wrangler line, a 2015-2017 JK is the best answer; it is not a teen-list vehicle.                                                                                                                              | NOTE |
| The listing data is unreliable  | Two adverts in this search had the wrong model year - the filter caught both from the VIN. Price, mileage and location are REPORTED. The engine rule reads a VIN pattern that held on every Wrangler examined; confirm at <a href="http://vpic.nhtsa.dot.gov">vpic.nhtsa.dot.gov</a> . | NOTE |

## 3. The filter rules

### 3.1 Model years

| Years     | Gen | Verdict     | Reason                                                                                     |
|-----------|-----|-------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1997      | TJ  | EXCLUDED    | TJ launch year                                                                             |
| 1998-1999 | TJ  | EXCLUDED    | Older TJ, not among the best-rated years                                                   |
| 2000-2001 | TJ  | EXCLUDED    | 0331 cylinder head prone to cracking                                                       |
| 2002      | TJ  | EXCLUDED    | Not among the best-rated TJ years                                                          |
| 2003-2004 | TJ  | TIER A      | Best TJ year: after the 0331 cylinder-head fix, before the 2005-06 oil pump drive failures |
| 2005-2006 | TJ  | CONDITIONAL | Needs documented oil pump drive assembly (OPDA) replacement                                |
| 2007      | JK  | EXCLUDED    | JK launch year: pronounced death wobble, airbag warning faults                             |
| 2008-2011 | JK  | EXCLUDED    | 3.8L V6 years: oil consumption past 100k mi, TIPM failures                                 |
| 2012      | JK  | EXCLUDED    | Worst-rated JK year: ~10 recalls, early Pentastar cylinder-head defect                     |
| 2013      | JK  | EXCLUDED    | Transmission failures and engine stalling reported                                         |
| 2014      | JK  | TIER B      | First JK year clear of the Pentastar cylinder-head defect; good rather than best           |
| 2015-2017 | JK  | TIER A      | Highest-rated JK years                                                                     |
| 2018      | JK  | EXCLUDED    | Run-out JK / JL launch: steering, weld and clutch complaints                               |
| 2019+     | JL  | EXCLUDED    | JL generation - outside this search and above budget                                       |

### 3.2 Other automatic exclusions

- **Engine** - TJs must carry the 4.0 inline six (VIN position 8 = S); JKs the 3.6 Pentastar (position 8 = G). This removes four-cylinder TJs and 3.8L JKs even when the advert says otherwise.
- **Check digit** - a VIN that fails is not a genuine VIN.
- **Title and channel** - salvage, rebuilt or flood titles; insurance-auction total losses; historical sales that are no longer for sale.
- **Country** - non-US listings (a Quebec car surfaced; importing adds cost and Quebec is heavy-salt).
- **Price** over \$12,000.
- **TJ frames from heavy-salt states** - a TJ frame rots from the inside out and cannot be economically repaired, so a TJ from the Northeast or Midwest is excluded outright. This is a policy choice; it is one line in the code if you want them reviewed instead.

### 3.3 Flags - kept, but a person must resolve them

Listing year contradicted by the VIN; price or mileage missing; priced over 15% below book; over 150,000 miles; flood region (Florida, Louisiana, Mississippi, Gulf-coast Texas); road-salt states; online auctions; modified vehicles; Unlimited body in a year whose book value starts above budget. Serious flags (below book, flood region, auction, modified, likely over budget) move a car from SHORTLIST to REVIEW.

Shortlisted cars are ranked by tier, then data completeness, mileage and climate, with a bonus for the JK - your stated preference, and the only generation with stability control.

## 4. What \$12,000 buys in the approved years

| Vehicle                 | KBB private-party         | Observed                                                      |
|-------------------------|---------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|
| 2014 JK Sport S, 2-dr   | \$10,930 - \$13,030       | Fair condition sits at \$10,930                               |
| 2014 JK Unlimited Sport | \$12,200 - \$14,450       | Starts above budget                                           |
| 2015 JK Sport, 2-dr     | \$11,440 - \$13,590       | Real listings: \$10,499 at 151,816 mi; \$12,495 at 148,000 mi |
| 2015 JK Sport S, 2-dr   | \$12,500 - \$14,900       |                                                               |
| 2015 JK Unlimited Sport | \$13,190 - \$15,790       | Above budget                                                  |
| 2016 JK Sport, 2-dr     | \$13,270 - \$15,620       | Real listing: \$10,995 at 155,451 mi                          |
| 2017 JK Sport S, 2-dr   | \$13,710 - \$15,810       | Nationwide listings start ~\$12,176                           |
| 2004 TJ (median)        | about \$9,000             | Listings \$9,198-\$10,995 at 94k-205k mi                      |
| 2005 / 2006 TJ (median) | about \$13,980 / \$10,950 | Conditional years                                             |

The pattern is consistent: high-mileage two-doors in 2014-2016 cluster between \$10,500 and \$12,500, 2017s begin just above your ceiling, and 2003-2004 TJs sit comfortably inside it. A 2016 at \$9,995 with 108,449 miles - which this search found - is 25% below the bottom of its book range. That is not a bargain until a title check proves it is one.

## 5. Filter results - all 28 vehicles

Generated directly by wrangler\_filter.py. VIN, year, generation and body come from the VIN; price, mileage and location are REPORTED.

| Decision  | VIN               | From VIN     | Reported listing                                      | Reasons and flags                                                                   |
|-----------|-------------------|--------------|-------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| SHORTLIST | 1C4AJWAGXFL566836 | 2015 JK 2-dr | Sport<br>\$11,499   miles n/a<br>n/a                  | ! Mileage not indexed<br>! Location not indexed                                     |
| SHORTLIST | 1C4AJWAG7FL574988 | 2015 JK 2-dr | Sport, automatic<br>price n/a   miles n/a<br>Mesa, AZ | ! Listing says 2014; VIN proves 2015<br>! No price indexed<br>! Mileage not indexed |
| SHORTLIST | 1C4AJWAG9GL189210 | 2016 JK 2-dr | Sport<br>price n/a   91,322 mi<br>Upland, CA          | ! No price indexed                                                                  |

| Decision    | VIN               | From VIN             | Reported listing                                                     | Reasons and flags                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|-------------|-------------------|----------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| SHORTLIST   | 1C4GJWAG1GL219309 | 2016 JK<br>2-dr      | Sport S<br>\$11,999   141,399 mi<br>Chantilly, VA                    | ! Heavy road-salt state - inspect frame and brake lines                                                                                                                                                                               |
| SHORTLIST   | 1C4AJWAG1EL160345 | 2014 JK<br>2-dr      | Sport, manual<br>price n/a   miles n/a<br>Apache Junction, AZ        | ! No price indexed<br>! Mileage not indexed                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| SHORTLIST   | 1C4AJWAG8EL147494 | 2014 JK<br>2-dr      | Sport<br>price n/a   miles n/a<br>Mesa, AZ                           | ! No price indexed<br>! Mileage not indexed                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| SHORTLIST   | 1J4FA49S34P771921 | 2004 TJ<br>2-dr      | Sport 4.0, 5-speed<br>manual<br>\$10,859   135,658 mi<br>Garner, NC  | ! Winter road treatment in NC - inspect the frame underside                                                                                                                                                                           |
| SHORTLIST   | 1C4AJWAG7EL190529 | 2014 JK<br>2-dr      | 6-speed manual<br>price n/a   118,489 mi<br>Woods Cross, UT          | ! Listing says 2015; VIN proves 2014<br>! No price indexed<br>! Winter road treatment in UT - inspect the frame underside                                                                                                             |
| CONDITIONAL | 1J4FA49S46P788486 | 2006 TJ<br>2-dr      | Sport 4.0<br>price n/a   miles n/a<br>Colorado Springs, CO           | ! Listing says 2023; VIN proves 2006<br>! No price indexed<br>! Mileage not indexed<br>! Winter road treatment in CO - inspect the frame underside                                                                                    |
| REVIEW      | 1C4BJWDG6FL569653 | 2015 JK<br>Unlimited | Unlimited Sport<br>price n/a   81,024 mi<br>La Crescenta, CA         | ! No price indexed<br>! Unlimited book value starts at \$13,190 - expect over budget                                                                                                                                                  |
| REVIEW      | 1C4AJWAG4GL250009 | 2016 JK<br>2-dr      | Sport<br>\$9,995   108,449 mi<br>n/a                                 | ! Priced 25% below book - assume a branded title until NMVTIS proves otherwise<br>! Location not indexed                                                                                                                              |
| REVIEW      | 1C4HJWDG0FL604925 | 2015 JK<br>Unlimited | Unlimited Sport<br>price n/a   miles n/a<br>TX                       | ! No price indexed<br>! Unlimited book value starts at \$13,190 - expect over budget<br>! Mileage not indexed<br>! Online auction - limited recourse, inspect before bidding<br>! Modified - verify lift geometry (death-wobble risk) |
| REVIEW      | 1C4BJWDG2FL735814 | 2015 JK<br>Unlimited | Unlimited Willys Wheeler<br>price n/a   84,824 mi<br>Houston, TX     | ! No price indexed<br>! Unlimited book value starts at \$13,190 - expect over budget<br>! Flood region - NMVTIS and a physical flood check are mandatory                                                                              |
| REVIEW      | 1J4FA39S83P324624 | 2003 TJ<br>2-dr      | X 4.0, 5-speed, hardtop<br>price n/a   60,830 mi<br>Jacksonville, FL | ! No price indexed<br>! Flood region - NMVTIS and a physical flood check are mandatory                                                                                                                                                |
| REVIEW      | 1C4BJWEG6EL123953 | 2014 JK<br>Unlimited | Unlimited<br>price n/a   122,634 mi<br>Englewood, CO                 | ! No price indexed<br>! Unlimited book value starts at \$12,200 - expect over budget<br>! Winter road treatment in CO - inspect the frame underside                                                                                   |

| Decision | VIN               | From VIN             | Reported listing                                                | Reasons and flags                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
|----------|-------------------|----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| REVIEW   | 1J4FA49S53P346697 | 2003 TJ<br>2-dr      | Sport 4.0, 5-speed<br>price n/a   145,000 mi<br>n/a             | ! No price indexed<br>! Online auction - limited recourse, inspect before bidding<br>! Location not indexed                                                                                                                                                                |
| EXCLUDED | 1C4AJWAG9FL630283 | 2015 JK<br>2-dr      | Sport<br>\$10,995   51,900 mi<br>Sherbrooke, QC                 | x Listed outside the US (Canada)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| EXCLUDED | 1J4AA2D1XAL173194 | 2010 JK<br>?         | Sport<br>\$10,700   111,535 mi<br>Lakewood, CO                  | x 2010: 3.8L V6 years: oil consumption past 100k mi, TIPM failures<br>x Engine code '1' is not the 3.6L Pentastar V6<br>! Winter road treatment in CO - inspect the frame underside                                                                                        |
| EXCLUDED | 1J4BA6H17BL574757 | 2011 JK<br>?         | Unlimited Rubicon<br>\$11,899   99,127 mi<br>Denver, CO         | x 2011: 3.8L V6 years: oil consumption past 100k mi, TIPM failures<br>x Engine code '1' is not the 3.6L Pentastar V6<br>! Winter road treatment in CO - inspect the frame underside                                                                                        |
| EXCLUDED | 1J4BA3H13BL589979 | 2011 JK<br>?         | Unlimited<br>price n/a   miles n/a<br>Littleton, CO             | x 2011: 3.8L V6 years: oil consumption past 100k mi, TIPM failures<br>x Engine code '1' is not the 3.6L Pentastar V6<br>! Listing says 2023; VIN proves 2011<br>! No price indexed<br>! Mileage not indexed<br>! Winter road treatment in CO - inspect the frame underside |
| EXCLUDED | 1C4AJWAG1CL117007 | 2012 JK<br>2-dr      | 2-door, manual<br>price n/a   54,371 mi<br>Englewood, CO        | x 2012: Worst-rated JK year: ~10 recalls, early Pentastar cylinder-head defect<br>! No price indexed<br>! Winter road treatment in CO - inspect the frame underside                                                                                                        |
| EXCLUDED | 1C4HJXDN9LW170163 | 2020 JL<br>Unlimited | Unlimited Willys (JL)<br>\$23,500   71,424 mi<br>Littleton, CO  | x 2020: JL generation - outside this search<br>x Price \$23,500 is over the \$12,000 ceiling<br>! Winter road treatment in CO - inspect the frame underside                                                                                                                |
| EXCLUDED | 1J4FA39S73P368341 | 2003 TJ<br>2-dr      | X 4.0, manual<br>\$10,500   188,500 mi<br>Hagerstown, MD        | x TJ from a heavy road-salt state (MD) - frame-rot risk<br>! High mileage (188,500)                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| EXCLUDED | 1J4FA49S03P360197 | 2003 TJ<br>2-dr      | Sport 4.0, automatic<br>price n/a   142,571 mi<br>Cleveland, OH | x TJ from a heavy road-salt state (OH) - frame-rot risk<br>! No price indexed                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| EXCLUDED | 1J4FA39S33P331285 | 2003 TJ<br>2-dr      | X 4.0<br>price n/a   98,065 mi<br>n/a                           | x Insurance auction - total-loss vehicle<br>! No price indexed                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| EXCLUDED | 1J4FA39S13P308152 | 2003 TJ<br>2-dr      | X 4.0<br>\$12,100   miles n/a<br>n/a                            | x Historical sale, not a current listing<br>x Price \$12,100 is over the \$12,000 ceiling<br>! Mileage not indexed                                                                                                                                                         |

| Decision        | VIN                      | From VIN               | Reported listing                                           | Reasons and flags                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|-----------------|--------------------------|------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>EXCLUDED</b> | <b>1J4FA69S34P755746</b> | <b>2004 TJ</b><br>2-dr | Rubicon<br>\$28,900   65,388 mi<br>n/a                     | x Price \$28,900 is over the \$12,000 ceiling<br>! Location not indexed                                                                                                                            |
| <b>EXCLUDED</b> | <b>1J4FA49S31P347487</b> | <b>2001 TJ</b><br>2-dr | Sport 4.0<br>price n/a   miles n/a<br>Colorado Springs, CO | x 2001: 0331 cylinder head prone to cracking<br>! Listing says 2022; VIN proves 2001<br>! No price indexed<br>! Mileage not indexed<br>! Winter road treatment in CO - inspect the frame underside |

## 6. Shortlist and next actions

| # | VIN                      | Car                                               | Next action                                                                                    |
|---|--------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 | <b>1C4AJWAGXFL566836</b> | 2015 JK 2-dr, tier A<br>n/a                       | Location and mileage - the price already fits.                                                 |
| 2 | <b>1C4AJWAG7FL574988</b> | 2015 JK 2-dr, tier A<br>Mesa, AZ                  | Price and mileage. Confirm automatic, as listed.                                               |
| 3 | <b>1C4AJWAG9GL189210</b> | 2016 JK 2-dr, tier A<br>Upland, CA                | Price first; it may book above budget. Lowest-mileage lead.                                    |
| 4 | <b>1C4GJWAG1GL219309</b> | 2016 JK 2-dr, tier A<br>Chantilly, VA             | Virginia salt: frame and brake-line photos before travelling.                                  |
| 5 | <b>1C4AJWAG1EL160345</b> | 2014 JK 2-dr, tier B<br>Apache Junction, AZ       | Price and mileage. Listed as a manual.                                                         |
| 6 | <b>1C4AJWAG8EL147494</b> | 2014 JK 2-dr, tier B<br>Mesa, AZ                  | Price and mileage.                                                                             |
| 7 | <b>1J4FA49S34P771921</b> | 2004 TJ 2-dr, tier A<br>Garner, NC                | Frame inspection (NC winter roads); confirm the teen can drive a manual; no stability control. |
| 8 | <b>1C4AJWAG7EL190529</b> | 2014 JK 2-dr, tier B<br>Woods Cross, UT           | Price. Advertised as a 2015, VIN says 2014 - price it as a 2014.                               |
| 9 | <b>1J4FA49S46P788486</b> | 2006 TJ 2-dr, conditional<br>Colorado Springs, CO | Only with OPDA replacement records; price and mileage unknown.                                 |

### Worth a second look from the REVIEW pile

**1C4AJWAG4GL250009** - 2016 Sport, \$9,995, 108,449 mi. If NMVTIS and CARFAX both come back clean, this becomes the best-value car in the report. Until then, assume a branded title. **1J4FA39S83P324624** - 2003 TJ X, 60,830 mi, hardtop, Jacksonville FL: remarkably low miles for a best-year TJ, but Florida means a flood check before anything else.

## 7. Leads still missing a VIN

These surfaced without a full VIN, so the filter cannot rule on them yet. Ask for the VIN and run it (Section 9).

| Vehicle                 | Price       | Miles       | Location       | Note                                     |
|-------------------------|-------------|-------------|----------------|------------------------------------------|
| 2015 JK Sport           | \$10,499    | 151,816     | not indexed    | High miles; in budget                    |
| 2016 JK Sport           | \$10,995    | 155,451     | not indexed    | High miles; best-rated year              |
| 2015 JK Sport           | \$11,995    | 134,251     | Clearwater, FL | Flood region                             |
| 2015 JK Sport           | not indexed | not indexed | Kingman, AZ    | Dry state                                |
| 2004 TJ Sport 4.0, 5-sp | \$9,999     | not indexed | Boerne, TX     | Hill Country, not the Gulf coast         |
| 2004 TJ                 | \$9,198     | 165,311     | Nashville, TN  | Moderate winter treatment                |
| 2004 TJ Sport 4.0       | \$10,000    | 205,463     | not indexed    | Very high miles                          |
| 2004 TJ Sport           | \$10,995    | 93,886      | Lewes, DE      | Would be auto-excluded: heavy-salt state |

## 8. Generation-specific inspection points

Use alongside the full Wrangler checklist in the Jeep report, Section 11.1.

| JK 2014-2017                                                                                                                                       |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <input type="checkbox"/> Death-wobble road test at 45-65 mph over seams, on a route you choose                                                     |
| <input type="checkbox"/> Track bar, ball joints, tie rods, steering damper for play                                                                |
| <input type="checkbox"/> Pentastar: cold-start noise, misfire codes; full OBD-II scan                                                              |
| <input type="checkbox"/> 4H engages and disengages cleanly; transfer case and differential leaks                                                   |
| <input type="checkbox"/> Confirm transmission from the listing (many 2014s are 6-speed manuals)                                                    |
| TJ 2003-2004 inline six                                                                                                                            |
| <input type="checkbox"/> Frame: tap the rails under the central skid plate and at the rear control-arm mounts - inside-out rot is the deal-breaker |
| <input type="checkbox"/> Cylinder head casting: confirm it is not a "0331" head (possible if the head was ever swapped)                            |
| <input type="checkbox"/> Oil leaks: timing cover, rear main seal, oil pan, valve cover                                                             |
| <input type="checkbox"/> Age items: steering components, bushings, wiring, soft-top or hardtop seals                                               |
| <input type="checkbox"/> Clutch and gearbox condition on the 5-speed manuals                                                                       |
| Every car                                                                                                                                          |
| <input type="checkbox"/> NMVTIS title check plus your own CARFAX or AutoCheck                                                                      |
| <input type="checkbox"/> Open recalls at <a href="https://www.nhtsa.gov/recalls">nhtsa.gov/recalls</a>                                             |
| <input type="checkbox"/> Three VIN plates match: dash, door jamb, frame stamping                                                                   |
| <input type="checkbox"/> Independent inspection by a shop you chose, before money moves                                                            |

## 9. Running the filter yourself

The listing sites this report could not reach will load in your browser. When you find a Wrangler, paste its VIN and listing details into the filter; it applies exactly the rules in Section 3.

```
$ python3 wrangler_filter.py 1C4AJWAG4GL250009 --price 9995 --miles 108449 --state AZ --city Phoenix

REVIEW      1C4AJWAG4GL250009  2016 JK 2-dr  $9,995 | 108,449 mi | Phoenix, AZ
! Priced 25% below book - assume a branded title until NMVTIS proves otherwise
```

Options: --price, --miles, --state (two-letter code), --city, --year (the year the advert claims, so contradictions are caught) and --channel (dealer, private, auction, insurance-auction). Running it with no arguments re-scores the full candidate set. Every rule - approved years, budget, book floors, salt and flood regions, the JK bonus - is a named constant at the top of the file.

## 10. Action plan

| # | Step                        | Detail                                                                                                                                                                      |
|---|-----------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 | Call the top four           | Upland CA 2016, Mesa AZ 2015, the \$11,499 2015, the Garner NC 2004 TJ. Get price, mileage, location, transmission and title status.                                        |
| 2 | Search, then filter         | CarGurus, Cars.com, Autotrader nationwide: Wrangler 2014-2017 2-door under \$12,500, and 2003-2004 under \$12,000. Run every VIN through wrangler_filter.py before calling. |
| 3 | Decide on the stretch       | If nothing clean appears at \$12,000, \$13,000-\$14,000 buys lower miles in the same years. Decide now, not at the dealer.                                                  |
| 4 | Title before travel         | NMVTIS plus your own history report on any car you would fly out for - mandatory on anything flagged below book or flood region.                                            |
| 5 | Remote inspection           | Independent shop near the seller, using Section 8. A refusal ends it.                                                                                                       |
| 6 | Fly and drive               | From Arizona or California, the drive home doubles as a long road test. Register with a DR 2698 VIN verification and a Colorado emissions test.                             |
| 7 | Winter tyres and 4WD lesson | Rated tyres before 1 September, and an empty-lot session on when to engage 4H - and when to take it out.                                                                    |

### The one-line summary

Buy a **2015-2016 JK two-door** from a dry state, with a clean title, ideally an automatic, for \$10,500-\$12,000 - and accept 100k-150k miles as the price of the right years at this budget. Choose a **2003-2004 TJ** only knowing it has no stability control. The filter will keep the bad years out of the search for you.

## 11. Sources

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Recovered through server-side search; listing sites could not be fetched directly.

### ***Model-year reliability***

- slashgear.com - best and worst Wrangler years; best and worst 4.0 engine years
- carscounsel.com / fatboysoffroad.com - TJ years to avoid (0331 head, OPDA)
- theautoinsiderblog.com - most reliable Wrangler years, 2026
- Earlier Jeep reports in this repository - JK year-by-year verdicts

### ***Safety***

- jk-forum.com / jeepspecs.com / rockcrawler.com - stability control introduced with the 2007 JK
- iihs.org - safe vehicles for teens (earlier teen-car report)

### ***Values and listings***

- kbb.com - 2014 Sport S 2D, 2015 Sport 2D values; listings
- iseecars.com / hagerty.com / conceptcarz.com - 2004-2006 TJ values
- cars.com / iseecars.com / truecar.com / carfax.com / cargurus.com - nationwide listings under \$12,000-\$15,000
- vms.autorevo.com dealer brochures; occasionbeaucage.com (Quebec)
- classic.com / Bring a Trailer; motorcarclassics.com; rmsothebys.com; bid.cars (IAAI) - TJ listings and sales
- hagerty.com / jk-forum.com / expeditionportal.com - rebuilt-title JK warnings

### ***Standards applied offline***

- ISO 3779 / 49 CFR Part 565 - VIN check digit (vin\_tools.py)
- wrangler\_filter.py - this report's rules, applied to every candidate

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Research support for a private purchase, not a history report, title search, inspection or professional advice. Listing data is REPORTED and time-sensitive.